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TikTok tradwives: femininity, reproduction, and social media

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ABSTRACT

In recent years, social media platforms have seen a growing promotion of the Tradwife's lifestyle, where cis women embrace patriarchal gender norms and identities such as the stay-at-home mother and homemaker. By encouraging young women to return to 'traditional lifestyles', these accounts argue that cis women will live more satisfactory lives. We argue that misogynistic influencer culture is not an exclusive output of masculine actors and that feminine content creators in the 'womanosphere' often play significant roles in rejecting feminist ideas of womanhood, particularly for young people. This paper examines TikTok as a haven for such discourse and analyses the underlying logics that govern this phenomenon. Our research ultimately asks, how do Tradwife influencers contribute to normalizing far-right, anti-feminist ideologies on social media? Specifically, we examine the intersection of traditional gender roles, reproductive futurism, and colonial nostalgia within the hashtag #Tradwife on TikTok to perpetuate these ideals.

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Tradwives; womanosphere; gender; whiteness; social media

Introduction

In May 2024, with curled blonde hair and a flowing pink dress, Estee Williams explains her experience as a Tradwife on 'Dr Phil'. 'Many women are realising that being a wife and mother is enough; you don't need a career to feel fulfilled,' Williams asserts, 'a lot of women support this. A lot of women want this.' At its core, the Tradwife movement encourages cisgender women to embrace traditional gender roles and identities, celebrating the roles of stay-at-home mothers and homemakers. Throughout the interview, the host, Dr. Phil, shares clips from Estee's TikTok account, where she declares, 'I submit and I serve my husband. This is biblical,' referencing Ephesians 5:22-25 in her captions. Currently boasting just under 200k followers on TikTok, Williams' does not have a limited reach, but rather part of a larger online trend where creators promote ultra-traditional marital roles. Other Tradwife influencers on TikTok all promote a romanticized vision of domestic life with copious baking, gingham aprons, and bible study.

In our increasingly digitized world, scholarship exploring male influencers and their promotion of conservative anti-feminist values is growing. These influencers (re)produce the

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'Manosphere', a term describing the broad network of forums, subcultures, blogs, and monetized courses that engage in increasingly sexist and extremist discourses (Daly and Reed 2022; Ging 2019; Haslop et al. 2024; Nagle 2015). These thought leaders, often termed 'Manfluencers', have received increasing attention for their cultivation of far-right, anti-feminist extremism across social media and alt-media platforms (Haslop et al. 2024; Roberts and Wescott 2024; Wescott, Roberts, and Zhao 2024; Zhao, Roberts, and Wescott 2024). Andrew Tate, perhaps the most disreputable, has become synonymous with online misogyny, creating content and selling online courses through a combination of commentary on athleticism, finances, how women are men's property and responsible for their sexual assault (CCDH 2022; Fallon 2023; Leeming 2023; Thorburn 2022). Despite being banned on most social media platforms and imprisoned on charges of rape and human trafficking, Tate's influence remains visible in classrooms across Australia and the UK (Haslop et al. 2024; Roberts and Wescott 2024; Wescott, Roberts, and Zhao 2024; Will 2023; Zhao, Roberts, and Wescott 2024). What emerges is a growing trend of young people, particularly boys, who believe feminism and contemporary gender dynamics victimize and subordinate men, often manifesting in normalized sexism, a disregard for female experiences and authority, and other harmful behaviours (Haslop et al. 2024; Roberts, S., a; Safer Schools 2023; Wescott, Roberts, and Zhao 2024; Zhao, Roberts, and Wescott 2024).

This paper, however, argues in line with a growing scholarship that this misogynistic influencer culture is not just composed of masculine actors, within feminine creators playing significant roles in normalizing far-right and anti-feminist ideals (Kay 2024; Procope Bell 2024; Silman 2025). As explored by Silman (2025), the 'womansphere' (also known as the femosphere) constructs a feminine response to the 'manosphere', where women articulate similar sentiments to their manfluencer counterparts; that contemporary 'woke' politics oppress conservatives and threaten their idealized (white) gender-essentialist worldview; where women are submissive homemakers and men are strong breadwinners. We argue that the phenomenon of Tradwives encapsulates this dynamic. While some women may find a sense of purpose in this movement, critics highlight the sexist nature of this ideology, where women are positioned as subservient, financially dependent, helpmeets to their male counterparts who possess absolute authority (Leidig 2023; Love 2020; Mattheis 2021; Proctor 2023; Tebaldi 2023). Furthermore, the Tradwife movement promotes normative gender roles historically rooted in white, colonial, and upper-middle-class understandings (Darby 2020; Leidig 2023; Mattheis 2021; Proctor 2023; Tebaldi 2023). What emerges are significant overlaps with the manosphere's white supremacist language and iconography, explicitly and implicitly (Darby 2020; Leidig 2023; Mattheis 2021; Proctor 2023; Tebaldi 2023).

The concept of Tradwives has emerged as a controversial phenomenon that intertwines traditional gender roles with harmful racial and political ideologies, with concerns arising over their influence on young people. While Simpson (2024) has highlighted the risk of young women idolizing these online influencers and emulating their lifestyles, others suggest that young men may be more susceptible. Notably, in 2024, the New York Times published an opinion piece titled "'Tradwife' Content Isn't Really for Women. It's for Men Who Want Submissive Wives," suggesting the target audience of such influencers is rather heterosexual men, affirming their desires in romantic counterparts (Grose 2024). While there is a risk of young women being influenced by the romanticized domesticity portrayed by Tradwives, the anti-feminist messaging these accounts espouse may also teach boys to expect these behaviours in partners.

To contribute to this growing literature on female influencers as anti-feminist propagandists and the broader ‘womansphere’, this paper examines TikTok as a haven for such discourse. Ultimately, our research aims to answer the question: how do female influencers within the Tradwife movement on TikTok contribute to normalizing far-right, anti-feminist ideologies on social media? Specifically, we examine the intersection of traditional hegemonic masculinity, reproductive futurism, and colonial nostalgia within the hashtag #Tradwife on the social media platform TikTok. In doing so, we observe how Tradwife influencers (re)produce anxieties surrounding the temporality of masculine, white, and colonialist values. Consequently, Tradwives craft this feminized echo of the traditional manosphere; a ‘womansphere’ (Silman 2025).

Methodology

Theoretical framework

Grounding our research, we draw on a post-structural feminist theoretical framework, which views the (re)construction of identities as socially and discursively produced (Prasad 2005, 165–166; Weedon 1997). This framework allows us to explore how Tradwives construct the feminine subject within the context of the contemporary Western world, focusing on how intersecting processes such as race, class, ethnicity, religion, and nationality (re)produce oppressive assemblages of ‘womanhood’ (Friedman 1998). Our research examined how constructions of gender, race, and colonialism serve as underlying logics governing the identity of the traditional wife, the intersection of traditional Christian gender roles, reproductive futurism, and colonial nostalgia within the hashtag #Tradwife.

Data collection

To understand the influence of Tradwives on young people, we conducted research on TikTok where a third of its U.S users were under the age of 14 (Zhong and Frenkel 2020). The research team created a research-specific TikTok account ensuring the account did not provide videos influenced by a pre-existing algorithm (WSJ Staff 2021). Once the account was created, we began liking content relating to Tradwives, following recommended Tradwife accounts and tailoring the feed by selecting the platform’s ‘I want to see more of this content’ reaction. Once the account had established a recommended algorithm, providing us Tradwife content organically on the platform’s For You Page, we downloaded the top 100 videos under the hashtag #Tradwife to they fell within our selection criteria as detailed below.

Criteria

- This study focuses on collecting TikTok videos produced by self-identified influencers promoting a ‘Tradwife’ lifestyle. For this research, we define an influencer as someone with 1,000 or more followers, which aligns with the *Influencer Marketing Hub’s* classification of influencers (2024). This ensures that the creators operate within a public influencer framework, likely producing content for an audience and as part of a commercialized, self-branded persona.

- Publicly available videos that explicitly engage with themes of traditional gender roles, stay-at-home motherhood, homemaking, and related topics that align with the concept of a Tradwife lifestyle, sincerely.

Data analysis

We employed Qualitative Content Analysis (QCA) to systematically analyse the videos and identify recurring themes within the Tradwife hashtag on TikTok. As defined by Zhang and Wildemuth (2009), QCA is a systematic, interpretive research method examining texts to identify underlying themes within their specific context. Doing so, 'allows researchers to understand social reality in a subjective but scientific manner' (Zhang and Wildemuth 2009, 1). Through QCA, we analysed both the visual and auditory elements of the video itself (imagery, editing style, music, voice-overs, and body language), the textual elements present in the video (captions and any other on-screen text), as well as the content creator's profile to contextualize our findings. We collected 102 posts from 61 influencers (see Figures 1–4 below).

Within our theoretical framework, our analysis focused on key themes such as traditional gender roles, reproductive futurism, and colonial nostalgia. We coded for phenomena related to the representation of gender norms, promotion of hetero-patriarchal values, ideals related to motherhood, homemaking, and submission, and nostalgia for historical periods that emphasize masculine authority and white colonial values. Both researchers analysed the same storage folder of videos, allowing each individual to review and code the data independently before discussing and refining the themes to reduce individual bias and strengthen the validity of the findings.

Ethics

Although this research involves publicly available data from social media, there remains the potential for influencers to feel their content is being used in a context unforeseen, particularly critical analysis of their personal positions. However, influencers, by definition, understand their content is to be viewed, engaged with, and shared across large networks. This is especially true for influencers who have cultivated substantial followings (1,000+ followers in our sample), as their content functions not just as a personal

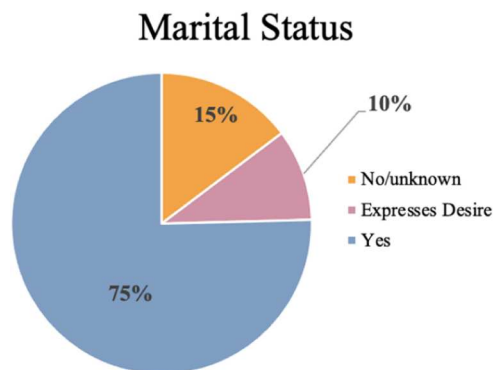


Figure 1. Marital status of sampled tradwife influencers.

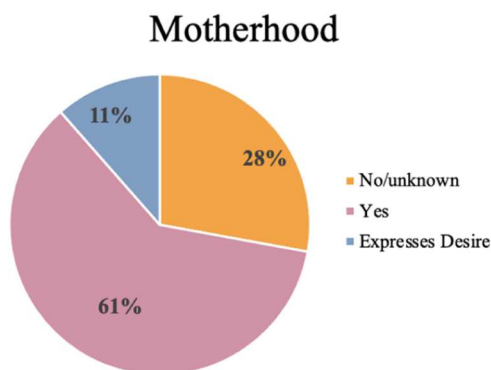


Figure 2. Motherhood status of sampled tradwife influencers.

expression but as part of a commercialized public-facing brand strategy. These individuals assume the associated public exposure by crafting videos to influence and engage others. As such, the scrutiny and analysis of their publicly available content in an academic context is consistent with how it means to be consumed and engaged with by an audience of unknown individuals.

Likewise, our analysis centred on the broader discursive patterns within the Tradwife movement rather than targeting individual influencers. While we limit identifying individual influencers by name or account in our publication, we acknowledge that some Tradwives have publicly spoken in traditional media, assuming roles as identifiable faces of the trend. In these cases, referencing these individuals was necessary for contextualization. This approach is approved by the University of Sydney Human Research Ethics Committee, approval number 2024/HE001584.

Discussion

'This is what a real woman looks like': hegemonic masculinity

A young white woman talks directly to the camera, filming a TikTok, discussing her frustrations with feminism, arguing no wonder young girls are turning away from corporatism

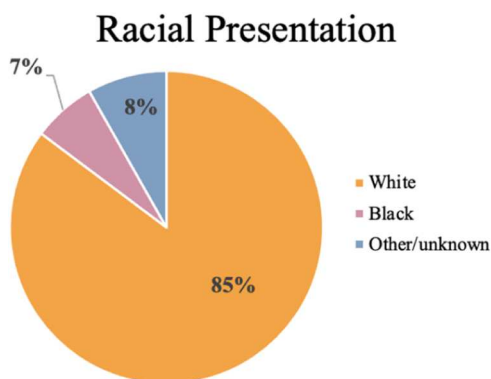


Figure 3. Racial presentation of sampled tradwife influencers.

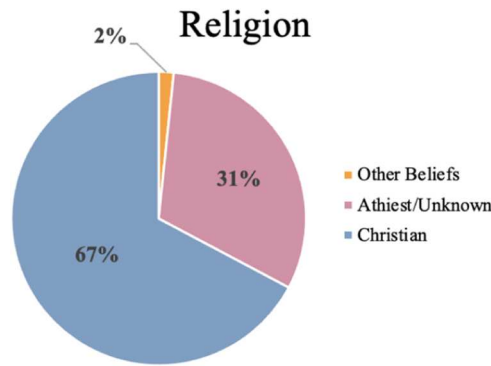


Figure 4. Religious beliefs of sampled tradwife influencers.

and pursuing a subservient role in the home, as women ‘naturally want a more traditional lifestyle.’ These rigid gender roles of the ‘breadwinning husband’ and ‘domestic subservient wife’ expressed by Tradwives point to a larger narrative involving hegemonic masculinity mirrored in the broader Manosphere. To discuss gender roles, we adopted Connell’s (1995, 71) understanding of gender; as a ‘reproductive arena.’ Therefore, we understand hegemonic masculinity as a concept that operates through the prioritization of a man’s dominant position in society and the subordination of femininity and other existing gender expressions (Schippers 2007). Hegemonic masculinity, when embodied by a majority of men, then legitimates men’s domination of women, becoming naturalized (Schippers 2007). Often neglected in the operation of hegemonic masculinity, however, is how women also facilitate anti-feminist rhetoric, ‘emphasized femininity’ and hegemonic femininity (Love 2020; Schippers 2007). Consistently, our data demonstrated how these women themselves uphold hegemonic gender roles through their promotion of biblical submissiveness and the naturalization of traditional femininity.

A large swath of our Tradwife content was religious, specifically Evangelical Christianity, conflating biblical submissiveness with womanhood. Many videos we sampled made explicit this connection, emphasizing the role of biblical subservience in heterosexual relationships as a means to be a ‘Godly’ wife or girlfriend. The emphasis on biblical submissiveness, heteronormativity and womanhood demonstrates the significance of hegemonic femininity in maintaining male dominance, male hegemony. One video featured two young women reading aloud Proverbs 31:10-31, exploring what it means to be a Godly woman. The Bible passage states how a God-serving wife should enrich a man’s life, wake up early to tend to the home, plan the day’s work alongside her daughters, and work late into the night. Another video featured a woman similarly reading from Genesis, recounting what the Bible outlines as a Godly marriage in the creation of Eve. Upon reflection, the influencer reiterates the message of Genesis: a marriage is between a man and a woman, as Eve was created to be a companion and helper for Adam. Repeatedly, through invocations of the bible, Tradwives reinforce heteronormative gender roles that assume wifely submissiveness to complement her husband’s leadership. These examples highlight how this subculture exists upon clear gender binaries. Masculinity is defined through its difference from femininity, and how femininity is defined to complement masculinity (Schippers 2007). If masculinity grants masculine bodies physical

dominance, femininity must therefore assume compliance, enabling the social practices to allow for masculine ascendancy (Schippers 2007). The literature on hegemonic masculinities and femininities is best reflected in biblical teachings of ‘complementarianism’ discussed by these Tradwives, the ‘equal but different’ social relations between men and women and their respective roles in the family (Shorter 2021). The social practices of hegemonic gender roles and complementarianism are further exemplified through the children of Tradwives, and their views on raising young girls. Several creators argued for teaching their daughters homemaking skills rather than allowing them to become breadwinners, stating directly how ‘women are to complement men’. As such, we can observe Tradwives perpetuating submission as vital to spiritually fulfilling marriages, thereby reproducing hegemonic gender roles, denoting men as natural leaders and restricting the choices of women to the domestic sphere.

The naturalization of feminine submission is a key component of the Tradwife movement, and an important facet of hegemonic gender roles in order to maintain masculine dominance. The notion of ‘natural’ occurred often in our sample, with several influencers stating how it is ‘only natural’ for women to return to traditional living, presenting a calm demeanour paired with a natural ease when tending to their household chores. Most Tradwives complete these chores whilst wearing hyper-feminine floral aprons or dresses, linen co-ords, or perfectly curled hair and makeup in the style of a white 1950s housewife. One video was simply depicting images in quick succession featuring cottage homes, white mothers and daughters, pet ducklings, and vintage artwork of 1950s relationships. This curation of a certain aesthetic; highly feminine, often white, and heavily romanticized, our Tradwives construct a naturalized traditional way of living and present it as universal (Mattheis 2021; Proctor 2023). It is ‘natural’ and ‘fulfilling’ for women to perform domestic labour. These influencers utilize historical periods which privilege white families and heteropatriarchal relations, ignoring the lived realities of marginalized communities referred to as ‘discourses of denial,’ (Bhopal 2020, 1; Proctor 2023). As 85.2% of creators in our sample were white (see Figure 3), we see this denial within the Tradwife trend itself, an emphasis on whiteness and white family dynamics as naturalized.

The creation of an aesthetic, however, implies a falsehood that is not ‘naturalized’. This paradox is something the viewers or the Tradwives themselves were wilfully ignorant of. Many of these women do not acknowledge how they had to give up an element of their agency, or leave their aspirations and identities behind. Hannah Neeleman, known by her TikTok account name ‘ballerinafarm’, is one of the most prominent mainstream Tradwife creators, amassing nearly 10 million TikTok followers in 2025. In 2024, Neeleman received significant attention for sharing her experience submitting to a more ‘Trad’ lifestyle, giving up her ambitions of training at Julliard to be a professional ballet dancer to instead ‘give up a piece of [herself],’ in the pursuit of homestead living (Agnew 2024). Decisions like these for many women, however, bear the cost of losing financial independence, exposing women to safety risks. Former Tradwives have given testimonies of leaving their traditional relationships, discussing the hardships they faced. One creator on TikTok featured a video of them in a food stamps office, with text stating how the Tradwife life for them has now left a 10-year job gap in her resume, affecting her economic future. In their maintenance of hegemonic gender roles and whiteness, a social system that centres on white men requiring the subordination of feminine bodies, it is these very women who are harmed. As noted by Love (2020) and Shorter (2021), many

women who engage in anti-feminist and white supremacist movements, that valorize 'Trad' lifestyles, have shared testimonies where they have faced physical abuse, domestic violence or even threats to their lives (Love 2020; Shorter 2021).

What is portrayed is simply not representative of how these women live. Despite critiquing feminist advances and the pursuit of work outside the home, many influencers invested significant time in non-domestic labour. It is important to note that 'influencing' itself is a business that can both be highly profitable and require a significant amount of labour, from filming, editing, posting, brand relationships, and advertising, which is in direct contrast to the financially dependent model these influencers extoll. Likewise, while romanticizing a stay-at-home lifestyle, which traditionally requires a family to live off a single income, many of these women run 'side hustles' such as selling their homestead goods, organic skincare, subscription services, or, for some, fetishizing the Tradwife aesthetic and operating an OnlyFans account. For example, Hannah Neeleman's rustic homestead is, in fact, a large working farm with hired labourers who help process the products her website sells (Agnew 2024). We often found these supplementary businesses through website links in captions or profile descriptions. These women are highlighting the paradox of 'choice feminism', a term defining the belief that any choice a woman makes is inherently feminist (Ferguson 2010; Proctor 2023). Tradwives often argue that their anti-feminist views are empowering to women, for they are choosing to live a traditional lifestyle, and suggesting it is the true way in which a woman should live. However, many of these Tradwife creators fail to address how their choices, such as leaving the job market to be a stay-at-home mother, are often unaffordable to others (Proctor 2023). The Tradwife trend is an illusion, with influencers shrouding their economic success as a byproduct of rustic stay-at-home mothering, or making little mention of their privileges, such as Hannah Neeleman's father-in-law being a billionaire aviation magnate (Agnew 2024). Despite their claims of self-sufficiency and the touted benefits of traditional living, the realities of this lifestyle are far from sustainable and often demonstrate immense privilege. These women embody the paradox of 'choice feminism', as they fail to recognize their own privilege in being able to 'choose' the Tradwife lifestyle, whilst denigrating feminism and undermining the lifestyles of other women.

Breeding away the left: reproductive futurism

Another critical finding from our research was how the concept of the Tradwife perpetuated white women as reproductive agents – a key factor to the preservation of conservative whiteness and its associated social structures. The centrality of reproduction and motherhood within TikTok Tradwives links directly to a broader ideology of 'reproductive futurism,' where producing offspring is framed as essential to the continuity of certain racial and cultural ideals (Schotten 2018, 37; Edelman 2020). In this view, motherhood is a duty and obligation tied to the survival and flourishing of specific cultural and racial identities.

A fundamental element we observed in the TikTok Tradwife aesthetic is the reduction of women reproductive agents, valorizing motherhood as both a cultural imperative and a racial duty. 85.2% of our sample were white, with 60.7% of them being mothers or expectant mothers and a further 11.5% expressing the desire to have children in future (see Figures 2 and 3). Against this racialized context, we observed an emphasis on

motherhood as the natural, historical, and biological calling for (white) women. The portrayal of 'trad' motherhood as an 'ancestral' practice was common, with many creators framing their role as stay-at-home mothers as a return to the values and traditions of their forebears – values under threat by feminist efforts to support women in entering the workforce. For example, we observed a trend of influencers integrating references to ancestry or 'ancestral' into profile names, descriptions or captions. One TikTok user stated, 'We want to go a little bit more back to our roots, to our ancestors, to the women who came before us. We like babies, we want to have babies ...' emphasizing that their commitment to motherhood is part of a larger cultural and racial legacy. Mirroring the biological essentialism typifying the manosphere (Vallerga and Zurbriggen 2022; Krendel 2020), we observe Tradwives invoking motherhood as a means to reduce women into their biological functions; a phenomenon rarely put towards fathers in the same spaces, instead, the womanosphere suggests that a woman's role to reproduce and nurture is a 'natural' biological inheritance.

Such discourse intersected with Christian fundamentalism, which encourages women to see their fertility as a divine duty. From our data (see Figure 4), 67.2% of influencers collected were openly Christian, often using their platforms to promote being a woman of God, exploring motherhood as a means to spiritual fulfilment, and serving God's will. One recurring TikTok audio used by Tradwife influencers argued that 'the only thing that you even have a chance of bringing into heaven is your children ... we get to create these souls that we're in charge of, and we get to guide them. Bone of my bone. They are our blood.' This rhetoric, emphasizing the creation and guiding of 'souls,' ties the act of reproduction not only to divine purpose but also to a racialized spiritual fulfilment. The reference to 'bone of my bone' and 'they are our blood' invokes a genealogical imperative, underscoring the centrality of biological reproduction in fulfilling God's will. Such language, 'blood' and 'bone,' implies that only biological motherhood is deemed spiritually fulfilling, reinforcing the boundaries of what constitutes a 'natural' family. The exclusion of non-biological forms of parenting suggests only those who reproduce within this narrow framework can achieve true spiritual redemption, aligning the sacred act of motherhood with the preservation of a homogenous, racially-defined family unit. The intersection of religion and biological determinism is further emphasized through another recurring TikTok audio that suggests, 'When God created men and women, more than just biologically different, our roles are meant to complement each other,' reinforcing the idea that women's natural and spiritual role is to reproduce and nurture. This is coupled with a strong rejection of transgender identities, which are seen as a direct challenge to the natural order, as one influencer commented, 'No one mansplains harder than a dude dressed like a chick trying to tell you, a woman, why they belong in your bathroom.' Such transphobic comments, often interwoven with anti-feminist and anti-LGBTQIA+ sentiment, underscore the belief that gender roles are immutable and that progressive 'liberation' from said roles, through feminism and LGBTQIA+ rights, is an existential threat to the survival of the white race (Mattheis 2021, 98).

TikTok Tradwives also often engaged in narratives of resistance to the so-called 'Great Replacement', believing non-white immigrants are replacing white populations and diluting Western cultural identity (Gonzalez 2022, 22; Mattheis 2021, 98). This anxiety manifests in various ways, often framed as a call to protect children from external, 'foreign' influences and ideologies that threaten to undermine the racial purity and cultural

integrity of white communities. One popular TikTok video encapsulates this sentiment, stating she voted for Trump so that her daughter would '... be protected from harm coming across the border illegally, to not have to compete against boys and men in her protected spaces ... freedom to worship JESUS.' This narrative echoes common white nationalist tropes about immigration and gendered violence, framing the protection of white Christian children from progressivist, queer, and – critically – 'foreign' threats as a fundamental political concern. The emphasis on 'freedom' and 'protection' is part of a larger mythos about defending the future of conservative whiteness by limiting the influence of non-white individuals and progressive ideas. This anxiety expressed by the Tradwife community overlaps with anxieties seen within the far-right and extreme right 'manosphere' communities, referred to as 'white woundedness'. Brown (2019) describes this 'white (male) woundedness' as a result of neoliberalism and repressive desublimation, culminating into a rejection of social obligation. This rejection of social obligation is then met with resentment and aggrievement, where those who have maintained power feel dethroned, justifying immoral affects and violence (Brown 2019). This 'white woundedness' and aggrieved entitlement, the feeling that something has been taken unjustly, is then expressed through calls for traditionalism, the closing of borders, white nationalism and heteronormativity as an attempt to stifle the communities who appear to benefit from progressivism and liberal democracy (Nilan et al. 2023; Roose et al. 2022). We found that influencers often positioned their traditional lifestyles as a means to protect Western values, one such influencer explicitly stating, 'Physically I'm making sourdough for my family. Mentally I'm overthrowing the government and saving the west.' This fear of racial and cultural replacement, or loss of power, is further symbolized through the use of specific visual cues, such as the white bicep emoji and national flags placed in captions, combined with nationalist and xenophobic rhetoric. Such behaviour presents motherhood and fertility as key acts of resistance against an onslaught of racial and cultural transformation. This overlap between the two communities, right-wing political extremism and Tradwife communities, is of great concern as these narratives are now cemented in mainstream content.

As TikTok saw the recent re-election of Donald Trump, the theme of the 'Great Replacement' became even more pronounced in Tradwife discourses. Following the November 2024 election results, many American feminists discussed following the 4B protest movement in South Korea, where, to protest growing misogyny in the state, women voluntarily forgoed dating, marriage, sex, and childbirth to negatively impact birth rates (Gao 2014). In response, TikTok Tradwives reaffirmed their own commitment to maintaining birth rates, one TikToker emphasizing, 'With the 4b movement taking off, I just want you to know I'll be doing my part to keep the birth rate from declining' alongside a white bicep emoji. We can observe how Tradwives frame their decisions to have children as acts of defiance against progressive protests, further demonstrating 'white woundedness'. In this narrative, preserving white birth rates is constructed as essential, fulfilling work. This emphasis on fertility as a racial duty, combined with the rejection of multiculturalism and progressive social movements, reinforces the idea that women's primary value lies in their role as reproducers of whiteness. This ideology directly ties reproductive futurism to white nationalism, where the future of the nation and the survival of the white race are seen as inextricably linked to the reproductive choices of white women (Bailey and Zita 2007; Martin, Trauthig, and Woolley 2024; Mattheis 2021). By framing women's bodies as the front lines in the battle

to preserve racial and cultural identity, TikTok Tradwives solidify their role in a larger political project that sees the protection of white hegemony as central to their mission. This protection of white hegemony and the deployment of 'white woundedness' further highlights the connection between Tradwives and extreme right masculinity, and the importance of white women in maintaining 'whiteness'.

(Home)making America great again: colonial nostalgia

In our data, we found a significant theme of colonial nostalgia; romanticizing an idealized past informed by their representations of the settler colonial frontier. This colonial nostalgia often intersects with anti-feminist and far-right rhetoric, seeking to reinforce 'traditional' gender roles, social and racial hierarchies, and libertarian values, framing contemporary progress as a threat to Western traditional values.

We found the #Tradwife trend, particularly among United States (US) influencers, evokes a longing for the socio-cultural tropes of the settler colonial frontier in their representation of the 'simpler' or 'ideal' lifestyle. In our research, Tradwives often explicitly engaged in colonial ideals, often through practising and championing homesteading to reject contemporary political and social complexities. In 26% of videos collected, predominantly US-based Tradwives touted small hobby farms; fetching fresh produce from their pet livestock, growing their own food, exalting pre-modern appliances, and emphasizing making meals rather than purchasing processed foods. In doing so, Tradwives construct a version of femininity borne from self-sufficiency and land cultivation.

However, this idealized vision of homesteading is inextricably linked to violent histories of land dispossession, where European settlers displaced Indigenous populations to claim ownership over 'untamed' lands (Reagin 2024; Smulders 2002). Through explicit captions such as, 'Physically I'm sweeping the porch. But mentally, I'm living my 1800s prairie wife dream,' or wearing 'prairie-style' dresses; we observed that influencers frequently drew parallels between their content and the Little House on the Prairie, emphasizing white settler families cultivating new homes and communities in the 'wilderness' (Reagin 2024). This romanticization is not innocent reverie, but an integral part of contemporary political discourse intersecting ethnic nationalism and radical right rhetoric. We can observe Tradwives espousing white possessive logics, whereby Indigenous lands are not simply bought by white settlers but transformed into a white settler property maintained, domesticated and owned as part of a greater white settler state (Moreton-Robinson 2015, vi-vii; K. Newman, personal correspondence, 22 January, 2025). Through romanticized floral aesthetics and cute livestock, the colonial nostalgia perpetuated by Tradwives often erases the violent white possessiveness of 'pioneering', where settler colonialists forcefully displaced Indigenous communities to take possession and 'civilize' un-settled country (Prowse 2016). As Kenny (2017, 258) argues, nostalgia is often an underestimated, potent tool in constructing these ideologies, providing a comforting, misguided vision of the past that appeals to a sense of longing for an imagined 'home'. The term nostalgia itself, derived from the Greek words *nostos* (return home) and *algia* (longing), represents a desire to return to an idealized time and place of perceived naturalization (Boym 2001, 7; Elgenius and Rydgren 2022, 1231).

Our research found that central to this ethos of self-reliance and disengagement is a deep-rooted scepticism towards institutional authority, often manifesting in anti-

intellectualism and distrust toward contemporary cultural and governance systems. One in five videos collected explicitly critiqued formal education, suggesting homeschooling was a safer, more effective route. We found that Tradwives often critique what they perceive as a 'woke leftist agenda' perpetuated in formal curricula, portraying it as unsafe and suggesting, as one video argued, 'just paying to be brainwashed.' In one video, an influencer perpetuates a well-known anti-trans conspiracy theory that young kids are encouraged to identify as animals in schools (Kingkade et al. 2022), suggesting homeschooling is one of the few measures a parent can take to ensure that their child does not identify as a horse. Instead of formal schooling, influencers in our data argued it is unempowering 'to rely on the system to educate your kids', it is a woman's place to be 'homeschooling her babies in the comfort and safety of their home,' and it is more important to teach daughters 'how to grow your own food' rather than 'academics.' This anti-intellectualism, however, is not merely about rejecting contemporary education but also about refurbishing a narrative of the past. Far-right movements often idealize pre-industrial, patriarchal societies as stable, where they assume gender roles were fixed, and intellectual and cultural life was simplified to preserve racial and social homogeneity (Leidig 2023, 99). As Blee (2003) argues, homeschooling in such contexts becomes a method to protect children from 'corrupting' influences of contemporary social and cultural shifts, fostering religious dogma and traditional values. The push to limit educational experiences, particularly for women, is a rejection of intellectualism and a deliberate attempt to restore a social order reminiscent of the colonial past, where women's roles were strictly circumscribed within the home and intellectualism was reserved for men. Furthermore, some scholars suggest efforts to train and teach others, as reflected in Tradwife subculture, mimic colonial missionary exercises, trying to teach the next generation and inform other women of biblical womanhood. Women were sought in colonial settlements for their 'civilizing' nature and their capabilities for breeding white children, but also to teach Indigenous children Christian values to erase their culture, particularly as it came to gender roles (Cruikshank and Grimshaw 2019; Edmonds and Carey 2016; Kosambi and Haggis 2000; Meissner and Whyte 2017). Thus, anti-intellectualism within the #Tradwife community serves as a conduit for a deeper, ideological desire to restore a racially and socially homogeneous, patriarchal society that both resists modernity and glorifies a pre-industrial vision of traditional life.

We likewise argue that this rejection of modern institutions extends to a strain of conspiracy. In our sample, we observed Tradwives engaging in anti-science and anti-government discourse, often dismissing modern science and health standards as harmful and occasionally conspiratorial. For instance, we observed Tradwives embracing 'chemophobia', a rejection of modern chemical products like medicines or food safety standards. Several videos claimed unpasteurized milk as a healthy, 'natural' alternative despite contamination risks and listeria, suggesting such risks are overstated, fictitious and perpetuated by 'Big Food Supply.' Likewise, we found several videos actively dismissing scientific facts, including videos that denied man-made climate change and others perpetuating the chemtrails conspiracy theory: a belief that aircraft condensation trails are government-funded biological weapon trials. 'Conspiracy' is a belief system that merges conspiracy theories with New Age spirituality, framing global crises and societal issues as covert agendas orchestrated by powerful elites while promoting spiritual awakening, health autonomy, and resistance to mainstream institutions (Ward and Voas 2011).

Asprem and Dyrendal (2015) notes how conspирituality reworks themes from Western ‘occulture’ and conspiracy theories, merging them with contemporary anxieties about authority and control. This stance, emphasizing self-sufficiency and distrust of government regulation, mirrors colonial-era narratives of rugged individualism and resistance to external powers, as seen in the settler motivations of defending ‘white values’ and ‘pure’ cultural traditions (Day and Carlson 2023). These beliefs further tie the Tradwife ethos to a rejection of government regulation, presenting a form of ideological self-sufficiency drawing from colonial ideas of independence, albeit in a domestic realm. The distrust of modern science and technology speaks to a broader anti-establishmentarianism that recalls settler-era ideologies of autonomy, self-sovereignty, and a deep-seated distrust of authority.

In our dataset, we observed many Tradwives vocalized support for Trump’s campaign, referencing his election slogan, ‘Make America Great Again’ in captions, audio, or wearing MAGA merchandise. This slogan encapsulates this longing to reclaim a time when life was perceived as more ordered, with conservative values, distinctions between gender roles and less state involvement. We can observe how this resonates with Tradwives, who reject modern governance systems, such as state-sponsored education and healthcare, viewing them as corrupt or intrusive. For Tradwives, a return to traditional family life, symbolized by home-schooling, home-birthing, and homesteading, mirrors the colonial settlers’ desire to isolate themselves from external authority while cultivating and controlling their homes and bodies. This nostalgic vision, however, is not neutral; Tradwives and the narratives they represent advocate their political cause of white nationalism and patriarchy (Prowse 2016; Smulders 2002). White women played an integral role in the establishment of the settler colony and the transformation of native land into an exploitable resource. By marketing this idealized lifestyle and remaking it as moral, attractive, and – crucially – non-violent, they are rewriting the history of North American colonization and race and gender relations in ways that actively erase displacement and genocide. By presenting a false narrative for the founding of the USA, their nostalgia is both a rejection of contemporary progressivism and governance and a valorization of the colonial project.

Conclusion

Whilst Manfluencers remain a significant issue facing young people and schools for their perpetuation of anti-feminist and white supremacist rhetoric, we contribute to a growing literature that female influencers can likewise (re)produce these narratives within a ‘womanosphere’ (Kay 2024; Procope Bell 2024; Silman 2025). Through an analysis of Tradwives on TikTok, we observed how logics of hegemonic masculinity, reproductive futurism and colonial nostalgia within this trend espouse and normalize the same anti-feminist and far-right white supremacist discourses. Such digital spaces play a critical role in constructing and romanticizing a certain form of femininity: one that is submissive, religious, white, maternal, self-sufficient, and sceptical of the government.

While some may suggest the moderation of social media as an effective tool to safeguard students and young people from such narratives, we hesitate to make such a recommendation. We write this paper as the banning, or censorship, of social media, has become a significant point of policy debate. As of January 2025, the US has since

delayed the banning of TikTok, and the Australian government has moved forward with their ban on social media on those under 16 years old (Amnesty 2024; Montgomery 2025). Amnesty International (2024) have critiqued Australia's social media ban, discussing how young people benefit from the inclusion and connection of social media. We also fear such bans will only push young people onto more radical platforms such as Telegram or Gab, which both house far-right and white supremacist communities (Al-Rawi 2021; Jones, Roberts, and Robards 2024; Scott 2025; Urman and Katz 2022). Moreover, as big-tech CEOs align themselves with the Trump Republican party, both X/Twitter and Meta/Facebook have removed important fact-checking safeguards, making it likely for misinformation and extremist ideals to further proliferate on these platforms (Bekiempis 2025; Booth 2025). As these policies develop, we stand wary of how students and young people will adapt, noting that the future of online discourses appears to be on a precipice that warrants continuing research.

In the interest of further research, we recommend academic inquiries that pivot away from a Western-centric focus on traditionalism, hegemonic masculinity and colonialism. In terms of anti-feminist feminine influencers, there is an opportunity for further exploration into how these identities are exported, adapted, or developed organically within non-Western contexts. We recognize the Western focus of such movements and think it is important that scholarship moves away to elucidate how traditionalism and anti-feminist movements uniquely function in the Global South.

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